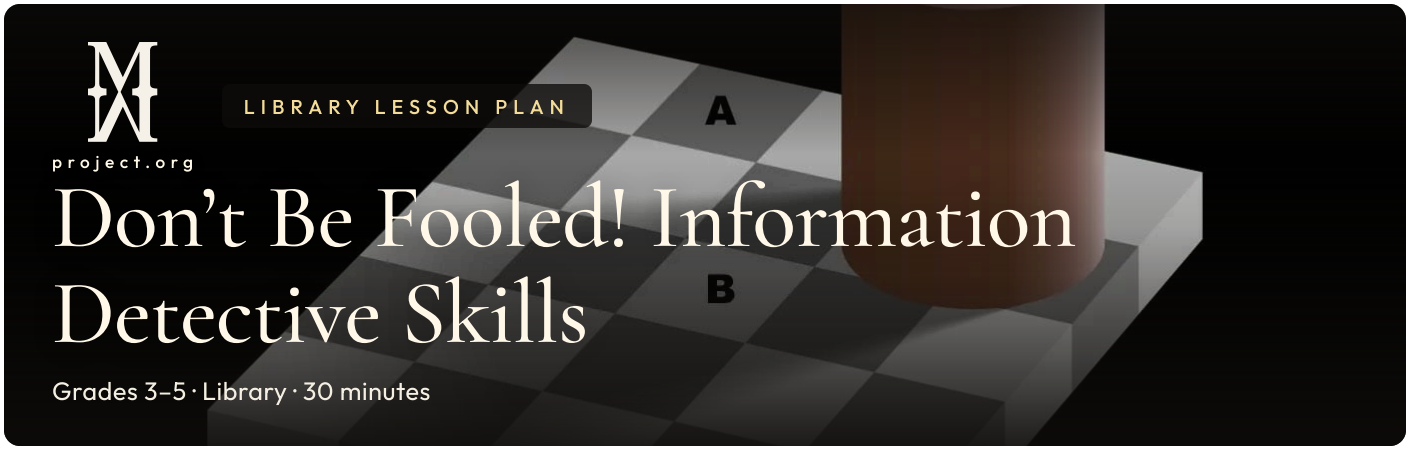


project.org

LIBRARY LESSON PLAN

Don't Be Fooled! Information Detective Skills

Grades 3–5 · Library · 30 minutes

Students connect optical illusions to information literacy, learning that just as our eyes can be tricked, we can be fooled by unreliable information — and developing the detective skills to tell the difference.

LESSON TIMING

5 min	5 min	8 min	8 min	3 min	2 min
HOOK	SPIRIT PHOTOGRAPHY	STOP-CHECK-ASK	REAL OR FAKE?	MUSEUM	CLOSE

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Students will understand that just as optical illusions trick our eyes, misleading information can trick our brains; learn the STOP-CHECK-ASK framework for evaluating information; and practice applying these skills to real examples.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **AASL I.B.3:** Learners generate new knowledge by generating products that illustrate learning.
- **AASL I.D.1:** Learners demonstrate mastery by selecting information in a variety of formats.
- **TEKS §110.5 (3) 13B:** Identify credibility of sources.

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Spirit photography examples from Mini Museum
- Sample "fake news" headlines (age-appropriate)
- STOP-CHECK-ASK poster or visual
- Mini Museum Perception Lab: minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving/illusions

RECOMMENDED BOOKS

- *Fake News: Separating Truth from Fiction* by Danielle Smith-Llera
- *True or False? A CIA Analyst's Guide* by Cindy L. Otis

LESSON PLAN · HOOK: TRICKING YOUR EYES · 5 MINUTES

Display 2–3 classic optical illusions. Let students vote on which line is longer, then reveal they're the same.

"Your eyes just got TRICKED. These are optical illusions — pictures that fool your brain. Now here's my question: If your eyes can be tricked by a simple picture… can your BRAIN be tricked by information?"

HISTORICAL CONNECTION: SPIRIT PHOTOGRAPHY · 5 MINUTES

Show spirit photography examples from the exhibition.

"Over 150 years ago, William Mumler claimed he could photograph ghosts. He charged grieving families lots of money to see images of their dead loved ones. Thousands believed it was real. Was it? No — he used 'double exposure' to fake it. This teaches us: just because something LOOKS real doesn't mean it IS real."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION: STOP-CHECK-ASK · 8 MINUTES

1 STOP
Before you believe it or share it, PAUSE! Don't let excitement push you to act fast.

2 CHECK
Who wrote this? When? Is it from a reliable place? Can you find the same info elsewhere?

3 ASK
Ask a trusted adult (librarian, teacher, parent) if you're not sure.

ACTIVITY: REAL OR FAKE? · 8 MINUTES

Present 3–4 examples and have students apply STOP-CHECK-ASK:

- *"Scientists discover chocolate is healthier than vegetables!"* — **Fake** (too good to be true)
- News article from known newspaper about local event — **Reliable** (known source, verifiable)
- Social media post with "facts" but no source — **Suspicious** (needs checking)
- Spirit photograph from 1870 — **Fake** (historical hoax)

For each: *"What step helps you here? STOP, CHECK, or ASK?"*

MINI MUSEUM EXPLORATION · 3 MINUTES

"When you visit the Mini Museum, look at the artifacts with your Information Detective skills. The Victorian illusion cards show how artists played with your eyes. The spirit photographs show how people can be fooled when they don't check sources. The lesson is the same across 150 years: LOOK CAREFULLY before you believe!"

CLOSING · 2 MINUTES

"Today you became Information Detectives. You learned that just like optical illusions trick your eyes, misleading information can trick your brain. But now you have a tool: STOP-CHECK-ASK. Use it whenever something seems surprising, exciting, or scary!"

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit: Spirit photography provides a powerful historical example of visual misinformation. Students see the challenge of distinguishing real from fake isn't new.

Option 2 — Virtual: Explore the exhibition online.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

DIFFERENTIATED STUDENT HANDOUTS

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

STOP-CHECK-ASK visual guide with simple scenarios.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Evaluate multiple sources, explain reasoning.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Research historical hoax, create misinformation awareness guide.

ASSESSMENT

- **Application:** Can students correctly apply STOP-CHECK-ASK to sample scenarios?
- **Understanding:** Can students explain why spirit photography fooled people?
- **Exit ticket:** *"Name one question you should ask before believing something online."*